

City Air Makes You Free

(if you are upper class or financially satisfied)

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We test hypothesis that cities are more free, and we do not find support for it except in Middle East/North Africa. If anything, there is some support of the contrary—greater freedom/autonomy in smaller places. But overall it is a mix and varies by region and country. East Asia/Pacific stands out with high effect sizes at about .4 or even .5, also controlling for other predictors of freedom. South Asia stands out as having large positive effect .3-.4 in the smallest category ($< 2k$). In particular in many regions or countries there is more freedom v large cities $> 500k$ in large towns mid-sized cities of $100 - 500k$ and $50 - 100k$ but slightly less in the smallest places $< 2k$. The effect sizes are large of about 4 steps on 1-10 income scale.

City life and Gesellschaft down the common people to decay and death. Ferdinand Toennies

In the city and therefore, where general conditions characteristic of the Gesellschaft prevail, only the upper strata, the rich and the cultured, are really active and alive. Ferdinand Toennies

City air makes you free (Stadt Luft macht frei) (Park et al. [1925] 1984, p. 12) originated in the Middle Ages, and it meant freedom from feudalism in cities, non-feudal islands in a sea of feudalism (Harvey 2012).

The parallel is somewhat a stretch (and the title is hook bait). The original saying was in Middle Ages and referred to freedom from feudalism in cities. Feudalism is long gone, although we may have techno feudalism (cite), but the idea does remain that cities are still more free than ruralities, especially for non-conformist types such as LGBTQ.

Some authors use term freedom (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2014) and some autonomy (Steckermeier 2022)—we use the terms interchangeably.

We test hypothesis that cities are more free, and we do not find support for it except in Middle East/North Africa. If anything, there is some support of the contrary—greater freedom/autonomy in smaller places.

It'd be already finding that ppl don't have more autonomy in cities, bc there are reasons and arguments that they do. And it is counterintuitive, city, just as the US appears the land of the free, but it is not. But I also have the case why there would be less autonomy in the city, just as there would be less in the West (especially the US) v Latin America—Mexico, Colombia and Venezuela are some of the most free countries in the World (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2014, Okulicz-Kozaryn and Martinez 2025). City (and the US) is stressed hectic anxious materialistic and consumerist (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2015) and overstimulating (Simmel 1903, Lederbogen et al. 2011)—in such conditions autonomy is difficult.

Freedom/autonomy can be counterintuitive—for instance the US advertises itself as “the land of the free” and yet people in the US feel less free at 7.7 than Mexicans and Colombians at above 8.1. Likewise, city may seem more free than ruralities, but as this paper argues usually that's not the case.

In the US v Latin America there is more social pressure,¹ and so a person in the US is more of an “automaton” (to use Fromm's term) (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2014).

¹Also see a fantastic book by Frank (2012) on keeping up with the Joneses in the US.

What is freedom/autonomy?² To be free is to be able to choose, to control and direct one's own life. Freedom is having control—a person is free if she is her own master. It could be labelled “psychological freedom:” “Freedom means a degree of harmony between basic motives and overt behavior” (Bay 1970, p.83 cited in Okulicz-Kozaryn 2014). It is “capability to choose,” “awareness of alternatives” and “courage to choose” (Veenhoven 2000).³ Clearly, there are more choices in city v ruralities, so at least in a sense more freedom. But then too much choice may also backfire and even lead to a paralysis (Schwartz 2004).

1 Literature

leonie help!

There are theoretical reasons to expect more freedom in cities v ruralities. In rurality there is mechanical solidarity—rural folks function like parts of a simple machine—groups are held together through homogeneity and similarity: similar lifestyles, roles, shared values and morality. Ruralities force social conformity not conducive for individual freedom (Durkheim [1893] 1997). Organic solidarity in cities allows for more differentiation and individualism. Likewise, there would be more *Gemeinschaft* in ruralities—more collective and social that may restrict personal freedom; and more *Gesellschaft* in urban that may promote individualism (but also hostility and aggression). Finally, Simmel observed that as urbanism overloads a person it forces a person to distance herself from the environment (Simmel 1903), which also may be conducive for differentiation and individualism. Urbanites are also more tolerant (Tuch 1987).

Many studies approach freedom as predictor of subjective wellbeing, but freedom is also an end itself (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2014), as recognized by Fromm (2013, 2012, 1992, 1964, 1944, [1941] 1994), Sen (2000). The Universal Declaration of Human Rights states that freedom is a human right: freedom for the realization of one's human potential (art. 26, 29).

There are many studies on the effect of urban-rural on subjective wellbeing (SWB) (e.g., Sørensen 2024, 2014, Knies 2026, Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2021), but the effect of urban-rural on freedom has only been studied once.

There are studies on freedom using WVS (e.g., Okulicz-Kozaryn 2014, Pitlik 2016, Nikolaev and Bennett 2016), but they do not examine urbanicity. The only such paper is Yamagishi et al. (2012), including among the papers that cite it.

Yamagishi et al. (2012) tests the “city air” hypothesis: the social constraints prevalent in rural life are weaker in metropolitan areas, freeing metropolitan residents from pressure to suppress their pursuit of individual goals. Yet their test is very different from ours—they show that urbanites are more likely to choose extravagant pens than rural folks. Still, the study is useful in at least 2 ways. First they show that indeed there is more freedom in city (using extravagant pens test), and they provide theory and literature summarized in the next paragraph.

Cities provide freedom from traditional rural social constraints—*Gesellschaft* v *Gemeinschaft*—deviation from community norms is more likely to be reprimanded and ostracized in rural v urban. An urbanite may be more internally driven rather than externally constrained rural folk. City provides more opportunities for alternative jobs and social relations, so urbanite is more free by being less concerned about social exclusion. Also see discussion in Luca et al. (2023).

One mechanism is higher social pressure for conformity in ruralities—cities provide anonymity—indeed concern for moral reputation is greater in rural than urban areas (Danielson et al 2023 cited in Okulicz-Kozaryn 2026). The higher the population density, the lower the frequency of social comparison measuring social comparison with searches on Google (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2026).

²Here we focus on personal as opposed to societal freedom and follow Okulicz-Kozaryn (2014).

³The degree of perceived control over choice is called “locus of control” in psychology and Verme (2009) argues that WVS item used here measures locus of control in addition to freedom.

2 Data and model

All data come from World Values Survey (WVS). WVS is a fantastic and free dataset available from <https://www.worldvaluessurvey.org>. It is a great source of data as compared to \$30k+ closed source Gallup data. It is helpful to use open source public data amidst corporatization of research and academia (?????).

WVS is representative of each country. Countries in the sample and sample sizes are shown in table ??

Autonomy/freedom variable reads "Some people feel they have completely free choice and control over their lives, while other people feel that what they do has no real effect on what happens to them. Please use this scale where 1 means 'none at all' and 10 means 'a great deal' to indicate how much freedom of choice and control you feel you have over the way your life turns out."

Validity and reliability of the measure seem fine and have been used successfully in the literature (e.g., Verme 2009, Inglehart et al. 2008, Veenhoven 2000, Okulicz-Kozaryn 2014) but still the question may be interpreted slightly differently in different languages/cultures, and some caution would be useful.

Other variables are listed in appendix and there also shown distributions of all variables TODO

We use World Bank regions classification into several regions: East Asia/Pacific, Europe/Central Asia, Latin America/Caribbean, Middle East/North Africa, North America, South Asia, and Sub-Saharan Africa. Countries in each region and sample sizes are in appendix.

Per controls we follow Pitlik (2016) except that we use financial satisfaction in most specifications instead of income as it arguably predicts freedom more than income and indeed in our sample correlates higher, and also we don't use their country level democracy index, and PCGDP in appendix only. Likewise, we have all person level predictors that Nikolaev and Bennett (2016) have used.

Money is important for freedom. Indeed as many financial gurus on YouTube would tell you freedom is the only or main reason to accumulate wealth in the first place. For instance, the FIRE movement (Financial Independence, Retire Early) is all about freedom/autonomy. Hence in our analyses we will focus on income, class and financial satisfaction. Financial satisfaction is the key—not everyone needs the same amount of money to be financially satisfied. It is measured as "How satisfied are you with the financial situation of your household?"

We were tempted to add trust, crime victimization and fear of crime, as these correlate with urbanicity and may predict freedom, and indeed inclusion of these yields larger coefficients.

But eventually we do not include them because those are rather caused by urbanicity, not the other way round, and hence may lead to overcontrol bias:

What we really need, to identify/estimate $X \rightarrow Y$, is to control for other determinants of Y that are also antecedents of X (so, $W \rightarrow X$). If we include controls where the relationship goes the other way ($X \rightarrow W$), we will exacerbate bias in our estimate of $X \rightarrow Y$. (The relevant term for that situation is 'overcontrol bias' (Bartram et al. 2024, p. 5).

3 Results

A natural first approach would be to find overall pattern on pooled complete dataset to see if there are universal patterns or at least by income group or region. Indeed this is how we have started, but we postpone these results to the appendix as we have learned through our sensitivity/robustness checks that inclusion of country dummies kills our results. Hence we simply start with the results by country.

4 By country

Is there less freedom in smaller areas as often argued? No. While most countries with significant results do show such pattern

11 out of 64 have at least one coefficient on either $< 20k$ or $20 - 500k$ ($v > 500k$) negative and significant at > 0.05 . 5 countries have positive effect. And most are insignificant at > 0.05 .

It is difficult to see any consistent country patterns in the table. Perhaps what stands out the most is that among the richer or more economically developed countries there are smaller differences. In poorer/less economically developed countries there are more differences mostly less freedom in smaller places⁴—this makes sense—smaller places in developing countries can be very traditional and very poor—freedom is difficult in such places; in richer countries on the other hand one can already be free just about anywhere, no need for a large city. This is also what happiness literature have found with respect to happiness (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2015)—only in the very poorest places of all such as sub-Saharan Africa happiness is greater in larger cities as life is unbearable and lacking necessities such as shelter and clean water in ruralities.

In table 1 we repeat full model from table 3 in appendix separately for each country. We collapse urbanicity to just 3 categories $lt20k$, $20-500k$, and $gt500k$ so that the sample sizes do not run too small. Still note that few countries lack the estimates as even this simplified 3 step urbanicity spectrum is not available. Overall it is a mix some countries one way some another, and many insignificant, but many more negative than positive. So in general within countries less freedom in smaller areas.

TODO go through this one more time make sure accurate with latest results!!!

Latin countries have lower freedom in smaller areas: ARG, BOL, CHL, NIC, PER South Asia does not have a clear pattern: BGD is positive, but IND highly negative. Europe/Central Asia: many insignificant, but otherwise mostly negative: CYP, KAZ, TJK, and TUR; and positive: ROU

East Asia/Pacific stood out earlier as mostly positive, but here: negative: highly positive THA, but negative JPN, MYS and several countries in East Asia/Pacific are without respondents in smaller areas: HKG, KOR, MAC, SGP, and VNM

Middle East/North Africa positive: MAR; negative: IRQ, LBN

Sub-Saharan Africa: ETH Negative but ZWE positive

⁴(but sometimes more)

	lt20k	20-500k	N
AND	-0.20+	0.00	997
ARG	-0.54*	-0.34+	849
ARM	0.19	-0.03	1192
AUS	0.04	-0.02	1575
BGD	0.31*	0.00	1197
BOL	-0.28*	-0.25*	1990
BRA	-0.30	-0.03	1687
CAN	0.04	0.08	4018
CHL	-0.19	-0.38*	903
CHN	-0.11	0.00	2775
COL	0.06	0.05	1520
CYP	-0.68*	0.00	943
CZE	-0.08	-0.05	1186
DEU	0.23	0.28+	1491
ECU	0.04	0.02	1184
EGY	-0.08	0.03	1175
ETH	-1.12	-1.43*	1215
GRC	0.02	0.15	1161
GTM	-0.06	-0.01	1113
HKG			2044
IDN	0.24	0.39	3154
IND	-0.69*	-1.12*	1063
IRN	0.24	0.18	1477
IRQ	-0.06	-0.36*	1177
JOR	0.04	0.10	1202
JPN	-0.22	-0.31*	1130
KAZ	-0.32*	-0.15	1116
KEN	-0.38	-0.02	1003
KGZ	-0.15	-0.05	1131
KOR		-0.03	1245
LBN	-0.66*	-0.39*	1200
LBY	0.21	-0.29	923
MAC			792
MAR	0.53*	0.28*	1200
MDV	0.17	0.00	1005
MEX	-0.11	-0.07	1619
MMR	-0.27	0.00	1200
MNG	0.18	0.50*	1638
MYS	-0.32*	-0.17	1313
NGA	0.80	0.16	1212
NIC	-0.42+	-0.20	1200
NLD	0.04	-0.12	1675
NZL	0.09	0.02	832
PAK	0.24+	-0.00	1966
PER	-0.65*	-0.33+	1387
PHL	-0.05	0.00	1199
PRI	0.10	0.00	1065
ROU	0.69*	0.56*	1088
RUS	-0.18	-0.06	1676
SGP			1966
SRB	-0.15	-0.25	980
SVK	-0.10	0.00	1175
THA	0.91*	1.29*	1258
TJK	-0.33+	-0.28	1200
TUN	-0.08	0.14	1073
TUR	-0.55*	-0.39*	2357
TWN	0.92	0.89	1221
UKR	-0.15	0.09	1116
URY	0.02	0.23	966
USA		-0.03	1758
UZB			1116
VEN	0.09	-0.18	1187
VNM		0.22	1200
ZWE	0.45*	0.00	1198
+0.10 *0.05 **0.01 ***0.001; robust std err			

Table 1: OLS regressions of freedom/agency using model controlling for age, age², male, married, employment type dummies(full/part time, self-employed, retired, housewife, student, unemployed, and ther), financial satisfaction, health, kids, and religion important. See model for pooled sample in table 3 except that original 8 step urbanicity variable is now categorized into 3 bins as there are smaller cell sizes separately country.

4.1 Interactions with financial satisfaction, class, and income

so then to probe further w try interactions with financial satisfactioun, striongest correlate of freedom (TODO double check and report at the beginnig of the results) and also related class and income. results are interesting–urbanicity categories are significant again even with country dummies (double check and report in appendix) and so are the interactonbs.

Urb rural is a gradient (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2017), but here for simplicity we we use $\geq 500k$ v small $\leq 10k$ (full gradient results in appendix) $\geq 500k$ represents city–indeed it could even be bigger than 500k–urban unhappiness appears around several hundred thousand (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2017).

By far the most differences are by financial satisfaction in panel a, those in top 3 categories are at about 8 v middle 3 at slightly

above 7 v bottom 4 at below 6.5. For the bottom categories there is very slight decrease from rural to urban, and for the middle and upper financial satisfaction categories there is a slight increase from rural to urban. The other 2 in panels b and c, class and income, don't matter that much. Income 3rd and 4th more free, but the top 5th less free. TODO: more interpretation and beautify the graph. Regressions are in appendix in table ??

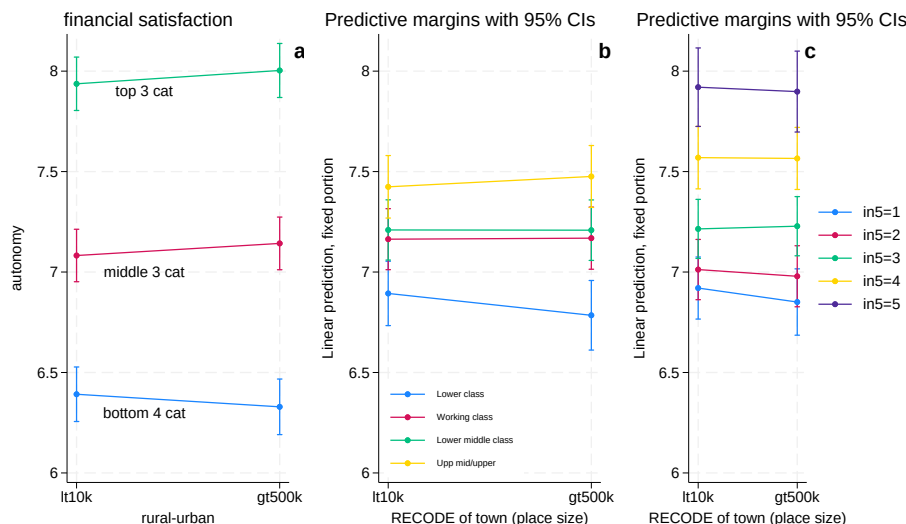


Figure 1: from table ?? in appendix

todo say what we contrl for like which spec from which table from earlier sec; and actual reg tables to appendix. it could be interesting to separate these results by country, however we leave it for the future research as sample sizes run small for interactions.

We do it by region and income group and postpone these results to appendix

5 Discussion and Conclusion

We find support for Toennies' idea: "in the city and therefore, where general conditions characteristic of the Gesellschaft prevail, only the upper strata, the rich and the cultured, are really active and alive" (Tönnies [1887] 2002, p. 227).

We test hypothesis that cities are more free, and we do not find support for it except in Middle East/North Africa. If anything, there is some support of the contrary—greater freedom/autonomy in smaller places. But overall it is a mix and varies by region and country. An interesting nuance is lower freedom for the smallest places $< 2k$ in Latin America/Caribbean. In particular in many regions or countries there is more freedom v large cities $> 500k$ in large towns mid-sized cities of $100 - 500k$ and $50 - 100k$ but slightly less in the smallest places $< 2k$. The effect sizes are large of about 4 steps on 1-10 income scale.

Like in Okulicz-Kozaryn (2024) urbanites probably actually have in a way fuller and more free life, but perhaps they realize more that they miss out relatively to other urbanites, and so they feel relatively less free. One mechanism could be that people tend to compare upwards (Frey and Stutzer 2002) and there are more people to compare to in urban areas, inequality ladders are taller and the pond is bigger—often it feels better to be big fish in a small pond (rural area).

It is worth highlighting that finding no effect would already have been a finding—the expectation from theory and literature is that the bigger places have more freedom

in poorer/less economically developed countries there are more differences mostly less freedom in smaller places⁵—this makes sense—

⁵(but sometimes more)

smaller places in developing countries can be very traditional and very poor—freedom is difficult in such places; in richer countries on the other hand one can already be free just about anywhere, no need for a large city. This is also what happiness literature have found with respect to happiness (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2015)—only in the very poorest places of all such as sub-Saharan Africa happiness is greater in larger cities as life is unbearable and lacking necessities such as shelter and clean water in ruralities.

ONLINE APPENDIX (SOM)

[note: this section will NOT be a part of the final version of the manuscript, but will be available online instead as SOM 'Supplementary Online Material']

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1 Additional info

1.1 Countries in each region and sample sizes

```
. bys region: ta cc
-----
-> regionname =
ISO 3166-1 |
alpha-3   |
country   |
code      |
-----+-----+-----+-----
      Freq.   Percent   Cum.
-----+-----+-----+-----
      NIR |      447      26.77    26.77
      TWN |     1,223      73.23   100.00
-----+-----+-----+-----
      Total |     1,670     100.00
-----+-----+-----+-----
-> regionname = East Asia/Pacific
ISO 3166-1 |
alpha-3   |
country   |
code      |
-----+-----+-----+-----
      Freq.   Percent   Cum.
-----+-----+-----+-----
      AUS |      1,813       7.29    7.29
      CHN |      3,036     12.21   19.50
      HKG |      2,075       8.35   27.85
      IDN |      3,200     12.87   40.72
      JPN |      1,353       5.44   46.16
      KOR |      1,245       5.01   51.16
      MAC |      1,023       4.11   55.28
      MMR |      1,200       4.83   60.10
      MNG |      1,638       6.59   66.69
      MYS |      1,313       5.28   71.97
      NZL |      1,057       4.25   76.22
      PHL |      1,200       4.83   81.05
      SGP |      2,012       8.09   89.14
      THA |      1,500       6.03   95.17
      VNM |      1,200       4.83  100.00
```

Total	24,865	100.00	
-> regionname = Europe/Central Asia			
ISO 3166-1 alpha-3 country code	Freq.	Percent	Cum.
AND	1,004	3.88	3.88
ARM	1,223	4.73	8.61
CYP	1,000	3.87	12.48
CZE	1,200	4.64	17.12
DEU	1,528	5.91	23.03
GBR	2,609	10.09	33.13
GRC	1,200	4.64	37.77
KAZ	1,276	4.94	42.70
KGZ	1,200	4.64	47.35
NLD	2,145	8.30	55.64
ROU	1,257	4.86	60.51
RUS	1,810	7.00	67.51
SRB	1,046	4.05	71.55
SVK	1,200	4.64	76.20
TJK	1,200	4.64	80.84
TUR	2,415	9.34	90.18
UKR	1,289	4.99	95.16
UZB	1,250	4.84	100.00
Total	25,852	100.00	
-> regionname = Latin America/Caribbean			
ISO 3166-1 alpha-3 country code	Freq.	Percent	Cum.
ARG	1,003	5.75	5.75
BOL	2,067	11.85	17.60
BRA	1,762	10.10	27.71
CHL	1,000	5.73	33.44
COL	1,520	8.72	42.16
ECU	1,200	6.88	49.04
GTM	1,229	7.05	56.09
MEX	1,741	9.98	66.07
NIC	1,200	6.88	72.95
PER	1,400	8.03	80.98
PRI	1,127	6.46	87.44
URY	1,000	5.73	93.18
VEN	1,190	6.82	100.00
Total	17,439	100.00	
-> regionname = Middle East/North Africa			
ISO 3166-1 alpha-3 country code	Freq.	Percent	Cum.
EGY	1,200	12.11	12.11
IRN	1,499	15.13	27.25
IRQ	1,200	12.11	39.36
JOR	1,203	12.14	51.50
LBN	1,200	12.11	63.62
LBY	1,196	12.07	75.69
MAR	1,200	12.11	87.81
TUN	1,208	12.19	100.00
Total	9,906	100.00	
-> regionname = North America			
ISO 3166-1 alpha-3 country code	Freq.	Percent	Cum.
CAN	4,018	60.75	60.75
USA	2,596	39.25	100.00
Total	6,614	100.00	
-> regionname = South Asia			
ISO 3166-1 alpha-3 country code	Freq.	Percent	Cum.
BGD	1,200	20.25	20.25
IND	1,692	28.55	48.80
MDV	1,039	17.53	66.33
PAK	1,995	33.67	100.00
Total	5,926	100.00	
-> regionname = Sub-Saharan Africa			
ISO 3166-1 alpha-3 country code	Freq.	Percent	Cum.
ETH	1,230	24.86	24.86
KEN	1,266	25.59	50.44
NGA	1,237	25.00	75.44
ZWE	1,215	24.56	100.00

1.2 var_des and Histograms

1.3 First/Initial results By region

These were our first/initial results but they do not hold when including country dummies and so we postpone them to appendix.

First for all regions in general there is more freedom in smaller areas v top bin, the base case ($> 500k$) in table 2 but controlling for other predictors in table 3 it is just the 2nd (2-5k) and 3rd (5-10k) smallest categories, and smaller values in 6th and 7th categories. But the very smallest areas ($< 2k$) are not more free. Next we separate by region.

East Asia/Pacific stands out with high effect sizes at about .4 or even .5, also controlling for other predictors of freedom. Europe is mostly less free in smaller areas. Latin America/Caribbean stands out with negative effect in the very smallest areas. Middle East/North Africa has mostly negative effects. North America is positive in 2nd largest category (100-500k). South Asia and Sub-Saharan Africa mostly do not show significant differences.⁶

	All region dummies	East Asia/Pacific	Europe/Central Asia	Latin America/Caribbean	Middle East/North Africa	North America	South Asia	Sub-Saharan Africa
town==2k	-0.05+	0.05	-0.13*	-0.28***	0.22	-0.07	0.01	-0.29
town==2-5k	0.14***	0.36***	0.09	-0.13	-0.09	-0.07	0.02	0.06
town==5-10k	0.20***	0.51***	0.03	-0.01	-0.12	0.13	0.03	0.35
town==10-20k	0.09**	0.52***	-0.15**	0.07	-0.34***	-0.03	-0.02	0.19
town==20-50k	0.12***	0.28***	0.08+	0.08	-0.17*	0.09	0.03	-0.22
town==50-100k	0.12***	0.41***	-0.10+	0.04	-0.02	0.12	-0.41+	-0.06
town==100-500k	0.08***	0.55***	-0.12**	-0.08+	-0.27***	0.18**	0.04	-0.45+
constant	6.94***	6.76***	7.06***	7.85***	6.88***	7.44***	7.52***	7.14***
N	93414	24560	25289	17285	9846	5833	5907	4694

+ 0.10 * 0.05 **
0.01 *** 0.001; robust std err

Table 2: OLS regressions of freedom/agency

	All region dummies	East Asia/Pacific	Europe/Central Asia	Latin America/Caribbean	Middle East/North Africa	North America	South Asia	Sub-Saharan Africa
town==2k	-0.03	-0.00	-0.03	-0.18**	0.02	-0.06	0.28*	-0.17
town==2-5k	0.09**	0.28***	0.00	-0.14	-0.13	-0.10	0.24+	0.18
town==5-10k	0.11***	0.36***	0.02	-0.03	-0.15+	-0.03	0.13	0.33
town==10-20k	0.03	0.41***	-0.20***	-0.00	-0.33***	-0.00	0.27	0.19
town==20-50k	0.04	0.24***	-0.01	-0.01	-0.22**	0.05	0.02	-0.17
town==50-100k	0.06*	0.34***	-0.21***	-0.01	-0.07	0.13+	0.10	0.02
town==100-500k	0.06**	0.48***	-0.18***	-0.03	-0.30***	0.13*	0.07	-0.43+
age	0.01***	0.01*	0.00	0.02**	0.00	0.03***	0.02	0.02
age2	-0.00***	-0.00**	-0.00	-0.00+	0.00	-0.00**	-0.00	-0.00
male	0.00	-0.09***	0.05	-0.08*	0.23***	-0.13**	0.16+	0.14
married or living together as married	-0.01	-0.00	-0.06+	-0.05	0.01	-0.00	0.06	0.27*
Full time	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
Part time	-0.10***	-0.04	-0.09+	-0.24***	-0.05	0.08	-0.32**	-0.06
Self employed	-0.07**	-0.12**	0.08	-0.04	-0.10	0.32***	-0.47***	0.15
Retired	-0.01	0.15**	-0.08	0.05	0.22*	-0.07	-0.31	-0.15
Housewife	-0.22***	-0.19***	-0.19***	-0.05	-0.17*	-0.05	-0.54***	-0.15
Students	-0.21***	-0.22***	-0.08	-0.27***	-0.21*	0.09	-0.31	-0.12
Unemployed	-0.10**	-0.11+	-0.16*	-0.02	-0.14	-0.14	-0.28+	0.12
Other	-0.23**	-0.29+	-0.34*	0.01	-0.20	-0.03	-1.87***	1.53**
financial satisfaction	0.27***	0.31***	0.31***	0.19***	0.31***	0.26***	0.31***	0.10***
health	0.34***	0.32***	0.25***	0.37***	0.47***	0.51***	0.21***	0.24***
How many children do you have	0.04***	-0.01	0.05***	0.02	0.10***	0.05**	0.03	-0.10*
religion important	0.06***	0.09***	0.01	0.03	0.37***	0.08***	0.17**	0.24*
constant	3.55***	3.23***	4.26***	4.79***	1.76***	2.89***	3.28***	4.26***
N	86653	23321	21600	16670	9427	5776	5231	4628

+ 0.10 * 0.05 **
0.01 *** 0.001; robust std err

Table 3: OLS regressions of freedom/agency

⁶Except .3 for South Asia for the smallest palces ($< 2k$).

1.4 Results With country dummies

Country dummies render cross-country patterns insignificant.

Here we conduct important sensitivity/robustness checks. First in a1 just urbanicity dummies. Then a1a adds region dummies like earlier in the first table little change. A1b has income level dummies TODO spell out; again little change; but addition of country dummies in a1c kills the significance and turns many categories negative notably the first smallest one, similar with controls in models a2* and country dummies make categories even more negative in a2c than in a1c. And then a1c2 and a2c2 add clustered standard errors on country (stata: robust cluster(country))—all significance disappears except in a2c2 on the smallest areas—hence only the very smallest areas $< 2k$ are less free than the largest ones $> 500k$.

in table 4 we conduct additional robustness checks, a1 and a2 are repeated from the body; a1a and a2a include region dummies: in a1a 100 – 500k results are attenuated, but others are stronger; and in a2a the top three categories spanning 20 – 500k are weaker but other categories are stronger and the smaller category $< 2k$ positive effect goes away. But then in a1c and a2c addition of country dummies kills the effects unfortunately. And having clustered standard errors yields all results insignificant

	a1	a1a	a1b	a1c	a1c2	a2	a2a	a2b	a2c	a2c2
town==<2k	-0.03	-0.05+	-0.03	-0.07*	-0.07	-0.06*	-0.03	-0.06*	-0.06+	-0.06
town==2-5k	0.08**	0.14***	0.10**	-0.05	-0.05	0.03	0.09**	0.04	-0.03	-0.03
town==5-10k	0.16***	0.20***	0.16***	0.00	0.00	0.07*	0.11***	0.07*	-0.02	-0.02
town==10-20k	0.03	0.09**	0.02	-0.12***	-0.12	0.00	0.03	-0.01	-0.09**	-0.09
town==20-50k	0.14***	0.12***	0.13***	-0.02	-0.02	0.07**	0.04	0.07**	-0.04	-0.04
town==50-100k	0.13***	0.12***	0.11***	-0.01	-0.01	0.10***	0.06*	0.08**	-0.01	-0.01
town==100-500k	0.13***	0.08***	0.11***	-0.02	-0.02	0.11***	0.06**	0.09***	-0.03	-0.03
age						0.01+	0.01***	0.00	0.02***	0.02***
age2						-0.00*	-0.00***	-0.00+	-0.00***	-0.00***
male						0.02	0.00	0.02	0.01	0.01
married or living together as married						-0.08***	-0.01	-0.07***	0.00	0.00
Full time						0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
Part time						-0.09***	-0.10***	-0.09**	-0.09***	-0.09*
Self employed						0.02	-0.07**	0.02	-0.02	-0.02
Retired						0.02	-0.01	0.01	-0.05+	-0.05
Housewife						-0.16***	-0.22***	-0.16***	-0.20***	-0.20***
Students						-0.19***	-0.21***	-0.19***	-0.14***	-0.14**
Unemployed						-0.01	-0.10**	-0.00	-0.11***	-0.11*
Other						-0.07	-0.23**	-0.04	-0.25***	-0.25*
financial satisfaction						0.27***	0.27***	0.27***	0.26***	0.26***
health						0.35***	0.34***	0.34***	0.34***	0.34***
How many children do you have						0.07***	0.04***	0.07***	0.02*	0.02
religion important						0.07***	0.06***	0.07***	0.03***	0.03*
region dummies	no	yes	no	no	no	no	yes	no	no	no
country dummies	no	no	no	yes	yes	no	no	no	yes	yes
income level dummies	no	no	yes	no	no	no	no	yes	no	no
constant	7.14***	6.94***	7.14***	7.57***	7.57***	3.84***	3.55***	3.87***	3.99***	3.99***
N	95083	93414	93414	95083	95083	87874	86653	86653	87874	87874

+ 0.10 * 0.05 **
0.01 *** 0.001; robust std err

Table 4: OLS regressions of freedom/agency

1.5 Main results from paper: Interactions with financial satisfaction, class, and income

	a	b	c
freedom			
lt10k	0.06	0.11+	0.07
10-100k	-0.07+	0.03	-0.01
100-500k	0.01	-0.05	0.07
gt500k	0.00	0.00	0.00
RECODE of satFin (financial satisfaction)=1	0.00		
RECODE of satFin (financial satisfaction)=2	0.81***		
RECODE of satFin (financial satisfaction)=3	1.67***		
lt10k × RECODE of satFin (financial satisfaction)=1	0.00		
lt10k × RECODE of satFin (financial satisfaction)=2	-0.12*		
lt10k × RECODE of satFin (financial satisfaction)=3	-0.13*		
10-100k × RECODE of satFin (financial satisfaction)=1	0.00		
10-100k × RECODE of satFin (financial satisfaction)=2	0.08+		
10-100k × RECODE of satFin (financial satisfaction)=3	-0.01		
100-500k × RECODE of satFin (financial satisfaction)=1	0.00		
100-500k × RECODE of satFin (financial satisfaction)=2	-0.04		
100-500k × RECODE of satFin (financial satisfaction)=3	-0.06		
gt500k × RECODE of satFin (financial satisfaction)=1	0.00		
gt500k × RECODE of satFin (financial satisfaction)=2	0.00		
gt500k × RECODE of satFin (financial satisfaction)=3	0.00		
age	0.01***	0.01*	0.01*
age2	-0.00***	-0.00	-0.00
male	0.01	0.01	-0.00
married or living together as married	0.01	0.06**	0.04*
Full time	0.00	0.00	0.00
Part time	-0.10***	-0.11***	-0.10***
Self employed	-0.02	-0.04+	-0.03
Retired	-0.06*	-0.03	-0.01
Housewife	-0.21***	-0.20***	-0.18***
Students	-0.14***	-0.12***	-0.11**
Unemployed	-0.14***	-0.22***	-0.18***
Other	-0.27***	-0.32***	-0.30***
health	0.37***	0.50***	0.49***
How many children do you have	0.01*	0.01+	0.01+
religion important	0.04***	0.05***	0.05***
Lower class		0.00	
Working class		0.38***	
Lower middle class		0.42***	
Upp mid/upper		0.69***	
lt10k × Lower class		0.00	
lt10k × Working class		-0.11	
lt10k × Lower middle class		-0.11	
lt10k × Upp mid/upper		-0.16*	
10-100k × Lower class		0.00	
10-100k × Working class		-0.09	
10-100k × Lower middle class		-0.03	
10-100k × Upp mid/upper		-0.04	
100-500k × Lower class		0.00	
100-500k × Working class		0.01	
100-500k × Lower middle class		0.03	
100-500k × Upp mid/upper		0.07	
gt500k × Lower class		0.00	
gt500k × Working class		0.00	
gt500k × Lower middle class		0.00	
gt500k × Upp mid/upper		0.00	
RECODE of inc (income)=1			0.00
RECODE of inc (income)=2			0.13*
RECODE of inc (income)=3			0.38***
RECODE of inc (income)=4			0.71***
RECODE of inc (income)=5			1.05***
lt10k × RECODE of inc (income)=1			0.00
lt10k × RECODE of inc (income)=2			-0.04
lt10k × RECODE of inc (income)=3			-0.08
lt10k × RECODE of inc (income)=4			-0.07
lt10k × RECODE of inc (income)=5			-0.05
10-100k × RECODE of inc (income)=1			0.00
10-100k × RECODE of inc (income)=2			-0.01
10-100k × RECODE of inc (income)=3			0.00
10-100k × RECODE of inc (income)=4			0.02
10-100k × RECODE of inc (income)=5			-0.04
100-500k × RECODE of inc (income)=1			0.00
100-500k × RECODE of inc (income)=2			-0.11
100-500k × RECODE of inc (income)=3			-0.05
100-500k × RECODE of inc (income)=4			-0.14
100-500k × RECODE of inc (income)=5			-0.27*
gt500k × RECODE of inc (income)=1			0.00
gt500k × RECODE of inc (income)=2			0.00
gt500k × RECODE of inc (income)=3			0.00
gt500k × RECODE of inc (income)=4			0.00
gt500k × RECODE of inc (income)=5			0.00
constant	4.51***	4.52***	4.61***
lnsl.1.1			
constant	-0.68***	-0.54***	-0.56***
lnsig.e			
constant	0.73***	0.76***	0.76***
N	87874	86391	86471

+ 0.10 * 0.05 ** 0.01 *** 0.001; robust std err

Table 5: OLS regressions of freedom/agency

1.6 By region and income group: Interactions with financial satisfaction, class, and income

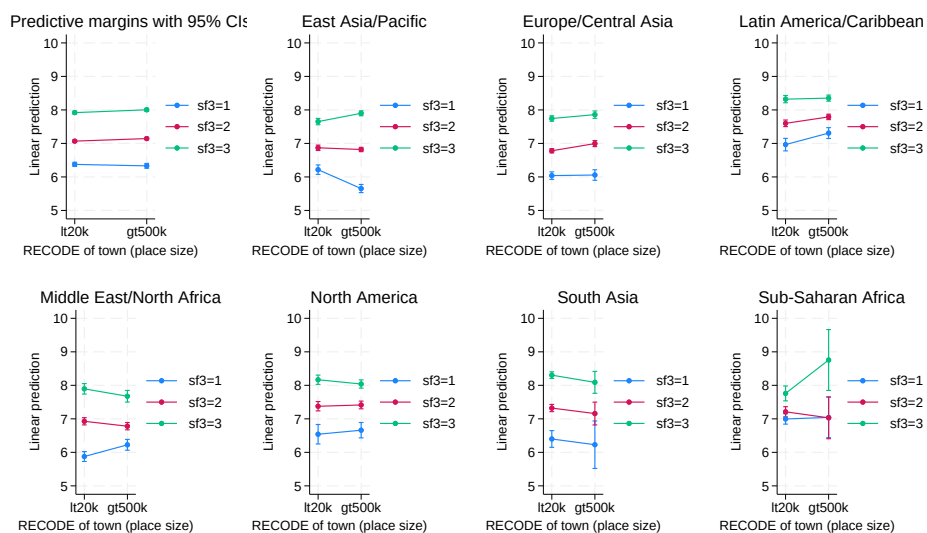


Figure 2: zzz

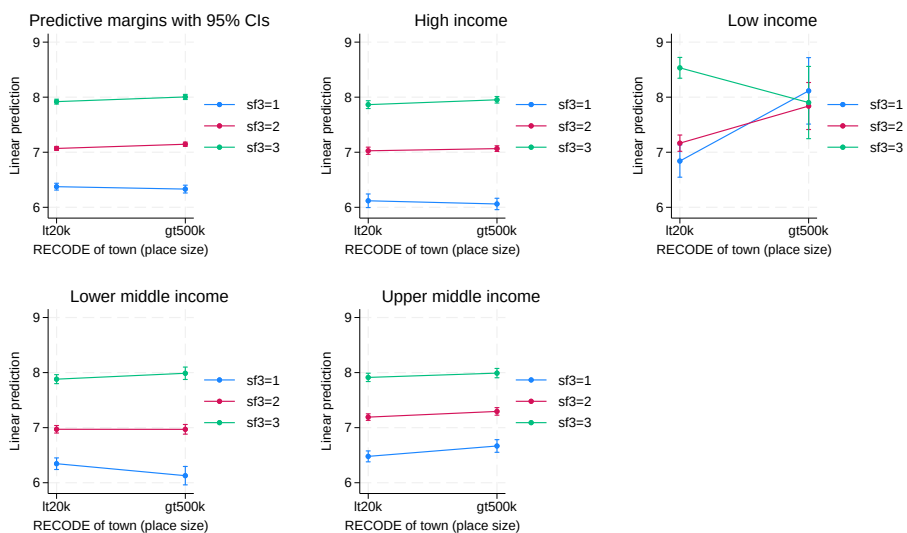


Figure 3: xxx; note just 2 countries for low inc ETH TJK

2 Auxiliary results and sidenotes

2.1 Some graphs

fig 4 and 5

weird to think that more ineq and pov would produce more freedom/autonomy; rather i guess lax capitalist friendly regulation would produce more ineq and pov, but should also produce less autonomy/freedom on avg, but it doesn't, there is positive relationship

or maybe the other way round: more freedom/autonomy more ineq and pov

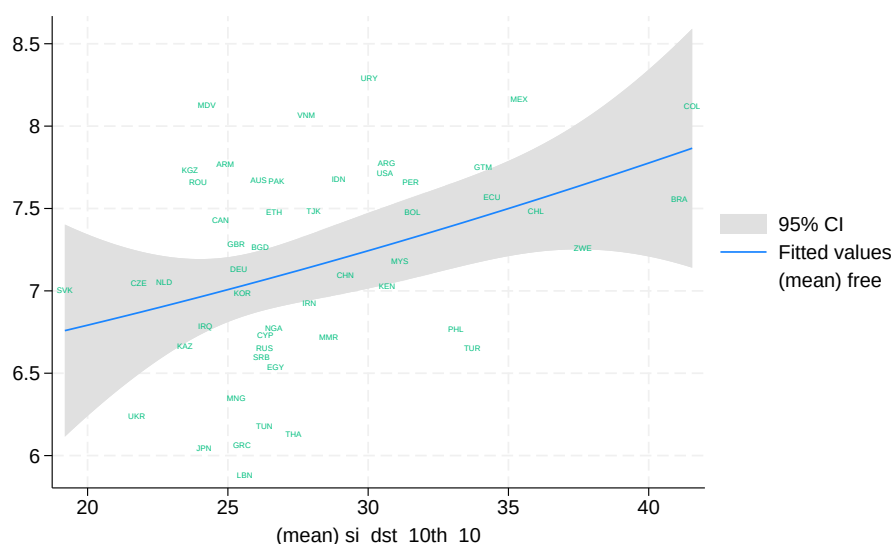


Figure 4: more ineq (inc share held by top 10perc, more autonomy—conservatives would like it!! and pretty strong corr .4

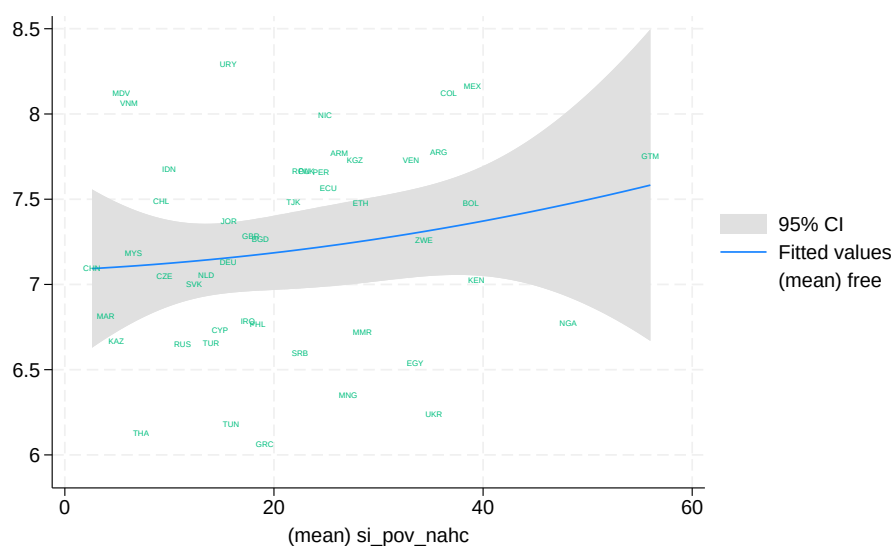


Figure 5: likewise with poverty, but here corr just .2

2.2 Literature

Newman (2020) makes some useful points that may be worth citing in full:

Social theory typically conceives of urban growth as associated with political freedom. [...] But not even in the most likely of cases did the city makes urban peasants free. Focusing on Mexico City, I argue that because rural-to-urban migrants became urban denizens by establishing squatter settlements, they entered into dependent relations with political elites, which reinforced a system of political dependency, or clientelist politics. [...] Mexico is, perhaps, the most iconic case. A large cross section of the peasantry rose in arms against landowning oligarchs in the insurrectionary phase of the Mexican Revolution (1910-1917), ultimately precipitating the wholesale reconstruction of the political order. Thereafter, peasants continued to mobilize for radical change, constituting a major obstacle to postrevolutionary governing elites who sought to consolidate control. [...] When a large and growing portion of rural-to-urban migrants live in squatter settlements, and

therefore have little recourse to legal protection in residential matters, they almost inevitably grow dependent on political elites—in an arrangement known as “clientelism.” Urban concentration gives rise to clientelism.

```
. tabstat ls, by(lwd7) stat(mean sd) format(%9.1f)
```

Summary for variables: ls
Group variable: lwd7 (RECODE of lwd (do what you like))

lwd7	Mean	SD
0-4	5.6	2.7
2	7.6	2.3
3	7.6	1.8
4	8.0	1.5
5	7.8	1.9
6	8.2	1.5
7	8.9	1.5
Total	8.3	1.9

.9

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